

The Strike

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It took less than forty-eight hours for the official corporate narrative to solidify, smoothing over the violent fracture of the heavy ore-carrier like resin over a cracked bulkhead. On paper, the Samson-47 hadn't suffered a near-fatal cascade of human negligence, panicked sabotage, and system failure. It had survived an "unprecedented micro-meteorite impact event" through the heroic, highly coordinated efforts of its crew. The Sol media feeds ate it up. The rewards were handed down in a cold, sterile ceremony beneath the polished light panels of the inner-system transit hub. Leila—the heiress—received a prestigious high-civilian commendation for "unwavering composure and leadership during a spatial crisis." Alex, her golden-boy Navy boyfriend, was awarded a medal for military valor, his academy record now permanently gilded. Even the low-born crew got their standard bone to chew on. Marek was handed two official corporate honors: one for Valor, and another specifically citing "exceptional technical competence under extreme operational distress." The Captain, however, was treated to a far more delicate corporate maneuver. He knew the truth, of course. He had pieced together the missing seconds on Alternator 5, the fried quantum module in sub-deck G7, and the sudden, miraculous revival of Sequence A. He had tried to corner Marek on the deck before the transfer ships arrived, wanting to confront him face-to-face. But the opportunities were short, choked by corporate liaisons and administrative escorts. They had exchanged only a few brief sentences in the quiet of the airlock corridor. What the Captain said in those few sentences kept Marek uneasy. The man spoke with a flat, disgusted realization, delivering a parting sentence so quietly scathing that Marek would spend the next two years replaying it in the dark, picking at the words like an open scab. The Captain knew Marek couldn't be quietly recycled—not after being publicly decorated by corporate PR. So, he did the next best thing. In his final incident assessment, he noted that while Tech-3 Marek had shown technical resourcefulness, he was "demonstrating severe psychological strain, operational fatigue, and an inability to function within standard crew hierarchies." He strongly recommended Marek be reassigned to solitary, low-priority utility duties. Specifically: the Cleaning Fleet. Marek hadn't fought it. He wanted it. He wanted to be as far away from Sol royalty, corporate politics, and heavy crewed freighters as the void would allow. As for the Captain, his reward was forced retirement wrapped in administrative silk. The corporation tried to park him in an instructor's chair at a remote Navy academy—a glorified desk position once held by an old officer. The Captain pushed back, demanding a flight deck, and was eventually demoted to a low-tier transport run. But shipboard rumors persisted that the man had struck a quiet, behind-the-scenes deal with Leila's family, and would be back in a command chair within a few years once the dust fully settled. Before his new deployment, Marek came back to the asteroid hub. On the surface, everything stayed the same, yet people quietly acknowledged him more than ever. During those first days, he felt genuinely proud of his new valor ribbon and his fresh assignment. Only Coval had tried to drag the real story out of him. Coval didn't buy the official micro-meteorite story for a second, driven by his own desperate curiosity. But Coval suffered his own personal meltdown. He had used every bit of his dwindling political leverage to get assigned to a surface survey team on a near-Sol asteroid. It was a rare privilege for a guy his age, near impossible to achieve, but despite suit shielding, he took a 1-in-1000 probable hit of radiation—exposing him to three times the lethal dose. He survived, barely, but he was put on red status: unfit for any real duty, facing the confiscation of the extra accesses and opportunities he still held. During those days, Marek visited him. They played the board game Marek had always refused to learn. This time, Marek endured the effort, staring at the small tanks moving across the hexagonal grid, getting outwitted and humiliated every single match. Still, he owed Coval. While the days were manageable, the nights were agonizing. Almost every single day, Marek waged internal monologue wars with Leila or the Captain. "The ship would disintegrate anyway!" "You meet me again and you threaten to kill me? Empty threats. You would be done anyway!" "I'm the biggest disappointing scum in your life? Maybe. But we live like that—not the good lads from the academy, but real people without any opportunity in life!" "You think you're better? You hid the real state of the ship! If you hadn't, I would have known better than to risk us all. It's your fault!" other days he agonising over Leila: "You didn't even need me! You were jumping across the entire ship while your boy was grieving! You knew the ship as well as all of us, so why did you need me or Adam? Weird that only Adam died. A trained astronaut dies from lack of oxygen

while you survive... Weird, isn't it? Or maybe easy to explain if you just stole his personal oxygen, and that's the sole reason you needed any of us. So his death is on your hands!" He went on like this every single evening, every single sleepless night, and it was agonizing. Yet he stayed away from alcohol and drugs. He knew from his early years that taking that path would seal his fate. Left completely alone, Marek accepted his new life in the deep vacuum.

The corporate Cleaning Fleet was a dead-end assignment, but it possessed one crucial feature that Marek craved: absolute isolation. Unlike the heavy ore-carriers or luxury transports, a sweeper vessel was tiny—a cramped engine block attached to a magnetic scoop array and a short-range thruster ring. The entire crew consisted of exactly one person. Across the entire sector, out of two thousand active cleaning units, almost every single one was a solitary operator. For the first six months, Marek forced himself into a rigid, robotic compliance. He told himself he was done overthinking. He wouldn't investigate anything. He wouldn't try to redesign the ship. He would just read the basic corporate instructions, clear the orbital debris, hit his quota, and keep his head down. It was grueling, soul-crushing work. The corporate debris quotas were set brutally high. The official sweeping procedures were absurdly inefficient, requiring complex, cautious maneuvers around minor space junk. Working strictly by the book, Marek barely made his numbers, scraping by at the very bottom of the 6-month period performance listings. Eventually, his true nature reasserted itself. Marek couldn't stop looking at the systems. He promised himself he wouldn't touch the blueprints, but his cynical, restless mind couldn't resist. He began diving into the sweeper's technical documentation. Despite the suffocating weight of the quota, the cramped tin can of a cockpit, and the looming threat of the ice mines, Marek found a strange, quiet exhilaration in the deep void. It hadn't started that way. In the beginning, there were endless, terrifying days when the silence of dead space pressed so hard against the glass that he wanted to scream until his throat bled. He was terrified, constantly tempted to slip back into his old follies—the panicked, self-sabotaging habits from his past. In those early dark stretches, his mind involuntarily dragged him back to the people he'd left behind. He would stare out into the black, his voice a dry rasp in the quiet cabin: "Look at me now, Captain... am I a disappointment?" He caught himself wishing Coval was there to bounce ideas off of, or bitterly muttering toward his younger Samson-47 team mates: "This is what you should be experiencing... not your rigid, soulless routines." Over time, though, he stopped doing even that. He systematically replaced thinking about people with an obsessive, deep study of technical manuals and hands-on experimentation. At forty-six—or forty-seven, depending on which corporate calendar you checked—sitting in the silence between sector boundaries, he was finally where he had wanted to be his entire life: out in the deep black, completely untethered. He loved the raw, unforgiving freedom of motion. Free from the claustrophobia of a station or the rigid hierarchy of an ore-carrier deck, Marek treated the sweeper like a private laboratory. He burned extra thruster fuel he couldn't afford just to test manual drift vectors, spent hours mapping out the decay of debris fields, and developed his own independent methods for finding scrap and predicting trajectories. His attempts didn't always work out as expected—more often than not, his rogue theories fell short of their grand design—but he was never left completely empty-handed, and it never dampened his eagerness for the cosmos. He was endlessly fascinated by everything around him. When a manual drift calculation hit within margin, he'd tap the display and whisper to the empty cockpit with a quiet, satisfied grin, "That was clever... damn, that was clever." He rewired his rig, jury-rigging a dual-antenna layout across the forward scoop array to facilitate his radio experiments. "One wire here... one here... and it should work," he'd mumble aloud to himself, crouching over the opened maintenance hatch with stripped copper between his teeth, running a custom web of cables across his bunk to squeeze out more power and transmit on non-standard frequencies. He mapped echo bounces off distant, natural obstacles, using iron asteroids like a makeshift radar array. No, he wasn't perfect. By the metrics of corporate tables and performance sheets, he wasn't even good—maybe not even average. He still had wild days full of foolish, dangerous ideas that he had to actively talk himself out of, placing a hand on the control console and taking a slow breath: "Calm down, Marek. Calm down. Keep it on the leash." But for the first time in his entire life, very slowly, he was getting calmer. Grounded. He pushed the sweeper's small engine block past its intended limits, listening to the hum of the hull and looking past Jupiter and Mars toward the wider solar system, murmuring to the stars, "I wish you could see me now..." In those isolated hours, when he was alone with his custom wiring and the vastness of the system, Marek wasn't just a bottom-tier trash collector struggling to survive—he was the ruler of his own tiny

domain, having legitimate, pure fun in the void. He was dreaming sometimes. He didn't know if it was a dream or not. He was jumping between stars, he could touch them, they were trying to tell him something, he was sure. He knew that this was a cosmic unvarnished language and he was a step away from understanding... yet not quite. But those were his best dreams; he couldn't reason about them, yet he felt a profound calmness.

And he dreamed this way for two years, meeting quota, mastering equipment—and yet... eventually, he got unlucky.

In the current period, he failed himself ever so slightly—a bit here, a bit there.

He was sitting at a catastrophic 55 to 60 percent below his required quota, with barely two months and a few days left in the cycle. At this rate, the math was simple and unforgiving: he was finished. Think, Marek. Think. Desperate to claw his way out of the hole before the final deadline, he began scanning the long-range arrays for a shortcut—anything to bridge the massive gap before the system shut him down for good. Obviously he was criticizing every single mandate the corporation had written. The standard operational procedures were laughably inefficient, written by desk-bound corporate bureaucrats who had never spent a day in a vacuum suit. Marek had always been cutting corners. He ignored the official sweeping trajectories, bypassed safety delays on the magnetic scoops, and rewrote his local thruster profiles. This was his *modus operandi*, but that habit came back to bite him today — there was no reserve, no margin, because he was always operating right at the edge of it, so there wasn't much room left to overreach further. "I have to," he muttered, secretly thrilled about it. But where to hit? Corporate reality was cruel and unforgiving. The corporation's quota policy was utterly ruthless: if an operator failed to hit their target numbers in any single cycle, they were summarily "retired"—stripped of their berth and sent back to whatever shithole they came from—or, if they'd damaged property, to ice-scraping under radiation, for life. Operating the way he always did, his numbers swung wildly. While steady, procedural operators like an adjacent-sector sweeper named Stephan smoothly logged consistent daily yields, Marek was constantly on the verge of total failure. Every half-year he barely made quota. He was skipping procedures, and his experiments rarely struck it big, but sometimes they weren't utter failures either. Often he'd think, "I pretend to be a scientist, but I'm just a gambler—it's always been this way," and he'd scold himself for it. But then he'd eventually win the prize. Those times he was really exalted; every scrap of dirt felt like a victory. And yet every time, he ended up near the bottom of the list of two thousand sweepers, hanging off the edge of the red line by a fraction of a percent. But this time was different—the situation was dire. Desperate to avoid falling below the quota threshold as the cycle drew to a close, Marek risked a long, unauthorized run to the extreme boundary of his sector. His long-range sensors had picked up a massive, dense cluster of high-value metallic scrap—enough to give him a gasp of hope. I have to just get there, he thought. Yeah, I shouldn't, but do I care? How far am I from my regular sector—did I ever care? "I'm justified. I have to," he reasoned with himself. When he started approaching, he already knew he'd lost again; his heart sank. Stephan—who always followed the rules—was already there, completely out of his assigned sector, illegally scooping the scrap hours ahead of Marek's arrival. It was unexpected. Yes, Marek played dirty, but this sucker Stephan was always in line. What had changed? Why now, when Marek was behind schedule? There was no point in quarreling; this game was lost, and maybe there would be a time for reprisal, but definitely not now. Yes, he was furious—"you sucker"—but it didn't help in the slightest. Marek sat in his tiny cockpit, watching Stephan's sweeper pull away with the haul. Panic and despair settled heavy in his chest. Even if he returned to his default sector and worked twenty-hour shifts, there was no way to recover the lost volume. He was cooked. He was going to miss the quota. And then he knew what he always knew: there was no escape from that, no avoiding it. There was no other way out—he had to double down on risk. Was this even his own idea? How were such crazy thoughts even conceived? They felt alien, ethereal, yet he had been fostering something in his mind for weeks, telling himself it would be big. He knew the feeling all too well: the urge to take the plunge once more. He tried to escape from that, tried not to think about it, yet he couldn't fully ignore it. Buried in a technical footnote on the magnetic scoop array—a detail no desk-bound corporate engineer expected a sweeper operator to read—was a single number: aperture calibrated to 60% rated structural tolerance. Sixty percent. Forty percent of the array's actual power was deliberately locked away, neutered to protect operators too stupid to manage their own thermal loads. He was forty-six, trapped in a tin can, and drowning at the bottom of the

quota board - "literally I have no choice". For three nights, he sat in the dim glow of his monitors, building stress models from scratch. He shaved the safety margins down, watching the math creep to the absolute edge of the redline. It wasn't reckless; it was brilliant. Expanding the aperture would widen the intake, allowing him to swallow massive debris in a single pass instead of three. The numbers held. Every time, the impact could be hard, but it stayed well within the tolerances of all systems. He executed the override out past his sector boundary, isolated in the cold void. His target was a massive, tumbling chunk of old hull scrap—a high-value score, just a handful of those could single-handedly rescue his numbers for the cycle. If he succeeds here he'd need to repeat the procedure just a few times, that's it. Marek adjusted the field geometry, cranked the coils past corporate tolerance, and drove the sweeper straight into the approach. For a fraction of a second, the raw math triumphed. The expanded field flared a violent, blinding purple, gripping the entire mass at once. Then the universe reminded Marek what his arrogant calculations had forgotten: real scrap isn't uniform. The boulder wasn't solid metal—it was a decayed lattice of corroded weld seams. Pushed past its safety margins, the scoop didn't gather the rock; it detonated it. The collision was brutal. The field collapsed inward, sending a kinetic shockwave straight back up the collector arm. The ship bucked like a slaughtered beast, snapping Marek's neck against his harness and throwing him violently sideways into the control bank. Alarm sirens shrieked. Loose tools violently rained off the bulkheads, and the entire vessel groaned as a sickening vibration rattled through its frame. When the violence finally stopped and Marek wiped the blood from his lip, the hold was empty. The boulder was gone, pulverized into a cloud of fist-sized shrapnel now scattered across a clean corridor. He had spent days modeling the stress on his own hull, but he had never once modeled the integrity of the target. It took him eight agonizing, exhausting days to sweep up the mess his own "genius" had created. Three wasted days he couldn't afford. Eight days that left him battered, bleeding time, and trapped in the exact desperate state Stephan had left him in: out of bounds, empty-handed, and hunting for one last score to replace the quota he had just pulverized trying to outsmart the system. He inspected the ship; it was all fine. That was the only good outcome—the actual simulation held, so he wasn't so stupid after all, though he was even more desperate for time. It seemed to him that the world was penalizing him for what he was. Unjust, unjust... He pounded himself. How far was he? Even including this scrap, he was still easily 50 percent from quota, and so little time remained—less than two months. It was over, at least at this rate. Think, think.

An official corporate notification flashed across his primary HUD. It was a mandatory, system-wide software update. The corporate memo attached to the file boasted a "significant 30% boost to sweeping efficiency through enhanced visual tracking and automated route optimization." There was, however, a small administrative caveat buried in the fine print: because of this "massive upgrade in efficiency," the baseline monthly quota for all sweepers was immediately increased by 10%.

That was an unexpected hit, and it hit hard. Marek thought his cynical nature made him immune to those things, but not this time—it moved him deeply. Deep down he knew... he has already developed a deep sense for such troubles and he shivers intuitively when he sees one.

Marek installed the patch. The new software interface was slicker, brighter, and certainly made long-range debris tracking look cleaner on the monitor. But within three days, Marek—and every experienced operator in the sector—realized the update was an absolute farce. The software didn't change the physical reality of space. The sweepers were already operating at the absolute limit of their thruster heat caps. Most single-person operators had long since compensated for the old software's flaws through pure hands-on experience and dangerous corner-cutting. The update made the screen look pretty, but it did not increase the actual rate of debris retrieval by a single kilogram. Yet the 10% quota hike was very real. A wave of bitter rage surged through the fleet. Over encrypted, sub-space operator channels—the untracked, low-frequency bands the sweepers used to talk shit about the brass—the discontent turned deafening. Operators who were already straining to meet their numbers were suddenly pushed under the red line. Even the veteran sweepers who comfortably met their quotas were furious. "If they can pull a fake 10% raise out of their ass now," one operator broadcasted, "they'll do it again in two years. They're squeezing us until we snap." The sweeping job wasn't prestigious, but it was one of the few high-paying vacuum contracts available to low-born workers. For many, it was the only thing keeping their families off the station

floor. This wasn't just an inconvenience; it was a career death sentence. The breaking point came forty-eight hours later. An operator in Sector 4, utterly panicked by his falling numbers, attempted a blind high-velocity sweep through an unstable asteroid cluster. His ship's primary drive exploded, tearing the hull apart. He survived the crash, but the corporate review board immediately ruled the incident a result of "gross operator negligence." Instead of receiving medical leave or a replacement hull, he was stripped of his contract and immediately reassigned to scraping ice on high-radiation comets. At least this was a rumor, and at this phase, that was more than enough.

The news hit the encrypted channels like a kinetic warhead. The anger shifted from quiet grievances to open revolt. Marek, who always felt detached from other people's petty problems, couldn't compose himself—he was triggered immensely this time. "I played the game right, you motherfuckers, like anybody here!!" He was cursing, he was nervous. We need to do something, we need to... It can't be like that. Corporate can't just... And he felt it: he wasn't alone. Every other person was feeling the same suffocating rage, the same shared anger ripping apart hearts and minds across the entire sector.

But this was not the end. The encrypted channel was bloated with messages calling for action. More and more, a few people came forward proposing something unthinkable. Marek stared in disbelief: a strike was called.

The logic behind the strike was solid, and the sweepers knew they held genuine leverage. Corporate safety regulations strictly dictated that if orbital cleaning operations ceased in a transit sector, all commercial and military traffic through that corridor had to be halted within three days. Without daily sweeps, even tiny bolts and micro-paint flecks moving at twelve kilometers a second would shred the high-value hulls of incoming corporate freighters. "Without us, the sector freezes!" the strike organizers shouted over the comms. "We hold the line, and they have to bend!" The plan was simple: every operator who agreed to join the strike would switch their ship's distress transponder to a synchronized "Message of Protest" broadcast, effectively locking their sweeping array, parking their vessels in the debris fields, and refusing to log hours. They gave the fleet a six-hour window to declare their solidarity. Marek sat in his cramped cockpit, watching the comms board light up. Initially, he was at a crossroads. Hating on corporate is one thing, saving your skin under stress and hiding in the shadow is another thing, but blatant disobedience is just another level—they do not let that pass. He was angry, very angry, yet reluctant. His paranoid mind screamed at him that the corporation would crush them. But as he listened to the speeches, an unfamiliar feeling began to bloom in his chest: genuine rage. He was angry about the guy sent to the ice. He was angry about the 10% quota. He was angry that they would take away the only thing he had. He was due with quota and he wouldn't make it anyway, so he would be demoted, turned back to his home asteroid empty-handed. "No" he would not yield that freedom so simply, no way. And there was something else, growing every minute, that kept him in it: he felt a strange, intoxicating sense of unity, like a drug. He was a sweeper. These were his people. He wasn't just a bitter, 46-year-old outcast hiding from his past—he was part of a collective front.

When the deadline hit, almost the entire fleet flipped their transponders. Thousands of sweepers went dark, locking their scoops in unison. Only a handful of cowards refused to join—including, who else, Stephan, the guy who had stolen Marek's scrap run. Marek felt a sting of hate immediately.

Among the strikers, a few fervent leaders quickly surfaced, flooding the channels with fiery speeches, demanding an immediate freeze on the 10% quota increase, immunity from corporate retaliation, and a mandatory "buffer month" to make up for lost time. There was also talk about the unfortunate fellow who went to the ice. Marek listened, his pulse racing, caught up in the wild, terrifying high of solidarity.

For the first four days, the corporation met the strike with complete silence. The excitement among the sweepers slowly began to curdle into anxious dread. Operators spent hours on the open comms, reassuring one another that the company was just bluffing, that the transit corridors were already choking on debris, and that the brass would break any minute. Marek's mood swung violently. One hour, he felt invincible, convinced they were making corporate history; the next, he was paralyzed by cold panic, picturing corporate security marshals ripping open his airlock. He secretly waited to see opposition against corporate rule his whole life, and now he was part of it. Yet they were simply ignored, brushed aside. How long would it take for food rations and logistics to

collapse on the protestors' side? Was unity real, or was everybody truly on their own? Was it a dream or real? Or maybe corporate was already picking them off, even while transponders were blinking all over the place in acts of defiance. Some who were undecided previously joined in a rush of unity, while other obstinate ones stayed out. "Cowards," murmured Marek, although he was swallowed by uncertainty himself. On the fifth day, the corporation finally responded. A formal, sector-wide administrative broadcast cut through every sweeper's HUD. The corporate voice was calm, sterile, and completely devoid of emotion: "All striking personnel are currently in violation of labor contracts. However, a grace period is now in effect. Any operator who deactivates their strike transponder and resumes cleaning operations within three hours will have the 10% quota increase temporarily waived for the current cycle. No disciplinary action will be recorded." The offer hit the fleet like a bucket of ice water. Marek felt that everybody was calculating the odds right now. It was tangible; he could almost feel what was happening in hundreds of other units, and his mind instantly began calculating. If I back out now, the new software interface really is a tiny bit better. With the 10% hike waived, I can hit my quota. I can survive the half-year. I can keep my ship. He looked at the transponder toggle on his dash. "What to do, what to do," time passed, agonizing minutes, hours. At times he was terrified. He envied guys like Stephan who had never joined the strike in the first place—they didn't have to carry the weight of this agonizing decision.

He was constantly battling himself—one moment strangled by fear, yet a second later dismissing it as nonsense. They responded—they felt our rage! It was an obvious hoax; they were trying to break our unity and then crush us individually. If we back down now—yes, it's safe, surely we avoid the ice—but it means retirement from any space or surface job regardless, made invisible to the system from now on. The writing was on the wall—he knew it, anybody knew it... or did they?

Meanwhile, the strike organizers rallied on the comms, furiously urging everyone to hold the line. "They are fearing us! If we set an example here, this will resonate throughout the Sol system, and they know it! They are acknowledging us!" Their demands grew even wilder—they now demanded hazard pay, full medical coverage for the guy sent to the ice, and complete immunity from future quota hikes. When the ultimatum elapsed, barely anybody had switched off their transponders. Hardly anyone was swayed. Marek saw hope: We are together. Unity holds. This filled his heart. He knew he was on the right side of history. The corporation waited another couple of days, letting the strikers stew in their own fear. Some people started to complain about food rations and the safety of their families, but other than that, the fierce speeches were effective. Unity held, moreover. The company tried to infringe on the territory with patrols. They apprehended a few protestors, but that was all—they couldn't legally penetrate, and there was even a rumor of a heavily damaged patrol ship.

There is no way back, thought Marek, not after this. It's either us or them. Yet staying in individual ships doing next to nothing was exhausting. What can I do besides listening to encoded channels? I just can't think straight, felt Marek. Yet he was excited—he felt like one of many. On other days, though, he thought about the impenetrable corporate machine. They could just win like that—nobody beats them. His mood kept swinging. Sometimes he observed maneuvers of other ships working like it was a normal day: "If you don't join, just step aside and wait on the sidelines, cowards!" But even with those few, space was too dangerous—they truly locked it down, denying any movement. Still, there were days when he knew it was all folly. They would be shot dead or sent to the ice eventually, even if corporate caved—they would come after them later, one by one. He felt uneasy about that. If they were to be safe, they had to stay together like always, and deep down Marek's independent mind feared that. Yes, participation was freeing and exhilarating, but they would be bound together basically for the rest of their lives, and that was a dreadful thought.

And then came the final corporate warning, their final ultimatum: "The grace period is closed. Effective immediately, the 10% quota increase is rolled out permanently to all sectors. The days spent on strike will be subtracted from remaining quota time. All operators remaining on strike are in direct violation of planetary law and subject to immediate contract termination and mandatory assignment to high-radiation ice-scraping facilities. You have two hours to comply by resuming work or face consequences including direct, violent confrontation. We have gathered sufficient resources, including cleaning capability from other sectors—you are no longer immune." It was an absolute execution order. Either return to work under worse conditions, or be dragged to the radiation pits. The mood shattered instantly. They knew it would come to this eventually, but still

they had been hopeful. For what? Hard to say. Corporate always wins regardless. The channel was booming with feverish speeches, but Marek was not in the mood. He wanted to stay silent and just be on his own. He flipped off the protest channel. He closed his eyes and started trembling, weighing his options. He had done his part; it was intoxicating, it was liberating. He knew he was doomed, but he hadn't met the quota anyway. If he flipped the transponder now, what would change? They would most likely honor the surrender and simply demote him to retirement—there would be no work in space or on the surface. He knew it. Yet he looked around, inspecting the interior of his ship, observing minor details of the construction. He tried to remember the actual purpose of the equipment; his mind was blank at first, but he tried to remember the actual function of the vessel. "Think, Marek, think." He stood up and started walking around the small hull, reciting aloud: "System of recycling air..." He started lecturing himself about the basic functions of the ship, touching almost every vital device around the piloting cockpit, going on and on "...main cooling pipe used for...", out loud. Two hours surely passed during this weird lecture... yet he hadn't moved toward the controls. Period concluded. Within two hours, over sixty percent of the fleet had surrendered, furiously firing up their thrusters to start sweeping again to save themselves from the ice. Only a bitter, desperate twenty-five percent remained, and Marek with them.

What happened next was extremely swift. Corporate security ships were already moving into the sector, actively hunting the remaining strikers, trapping their tiny ships in the heavy debris fields, and arresting the operators. Marek went numb. He was a rogue now, an outcast, a pirate—so what, a few hours and it would all be over. "Nonsense, nonsense." Then a sudden rush of rage swept through him. Now I am on my own, and I will show you what I am made of. Wait and see. He knew he was trapped. He couldn't go home—corporate security would flag his berth the moment his sweeper docked. He couldn't run. But he knew his sector like no other in the universe; he would dodge, he would... He started analyzing thruster options for hideouts and further plans.

Swinging wildly between blind terror and sheer despair, Marek maneuvered his tiny ship into a dense, unmapped field of heavy iron asteroids, cutting his main engines and trying to dig in. He refused to switch his transponder off—go and get me here, motherfuckers, only I know how to navigate in this deadly labyrinth. He wouldn't give them the satisfaction of a clean surrender. He sat in the dark cockpit, shivering in his flight suit, listening to his own ragged breathing, waiting for the marshals to find him. Then he noticed them. I have nothing to lose. Chase me, chase me now, motherfuckers! But something crazy crossed his mind. This new software update, mediocre as it was, revealed a few dirt boulders right around the corner. I know what I'll do if I push from close distance... No matter what kind of slick boy you are, we die together! Marek went mad: ice or die fighting. He started calculating the maneuver and slammed the acceleration. Is it crazy? Maybe—I think I always was. "I will fight suckers like you. Fuck you!"

A heavy corporate patrol cutter drifted through the outer edge of the asteroid field, its long-range scanning array sweeping the spinning rocks. Inside the cutter's bridge, two security officers sat casually in front of their tracking monitors, sipping synthetic coffee. "Got a hit on sector grid 4-7," the junior officer said, tapping his screen. "Tiny sweeper hiding in the shadow of a nickel-iron mass. Looks like another strike holdout." The senior officer pulled up the target's registry file and blinked in surprise. "Wait... look at the service ID. That's Tech-3 Marek. The old station rat from the Samson-47 incident." The junior officer raised an eyebrow. "The guy who got the Valor commendation? What the hell has he been doing the last few days? Not much of a protester, his transponder was silent the entire time. We have to look at this." The senior officer shrugged. "No, he always acts out of the ordinary—never sticks to a checklist. But his transponder is damaged; we're just getting weak gibberish. Message him on radio and visual to let him know. Threat level is zero, but keeping a transponder operational is mandatory. His numbers are garbage anyway—why does corporate even keep him around?" The senior officer sighed, reaching for the short-range light-comms toggle. "His transponder must be completely busted. He probably doesn't even know anything. Flash him with the optical laser. Tell him to fix his rig and get back to work before he gets himself recycled."

Initially, Marek was so captured by his state-of-the-art suicide maneuver that he ignored the transmission. Then it started to sink in. In the dark cockpit of his sweeper, Marek froze as a bright, pulsing visual beam flashed against his forward viewport. It was optical Morse code from the nearby patrol cutter. Marek stared at the blinking light, his mind struggling to process the visual translation

running across his HUD: [YOUR TRANSPONDER IS BROKEN][YOU ARE SENDING GIBBERISH SIGNALS][REPAIR IMMEDIATELY][STRIKE IS OVER - RESUME SWEEPING] Marek sat in absolute, stunned silence for ten solid minutes. He confirmed reception finally. Is he a pirate or not? He had triggered energy that was deadly for nothing. Is this a scam? Yet they flew away... What was going on? Hands shaking uncontrollably, he unbuckled his harness, crawled into the rear maintenance hatch of his tiny vessel, and cracked open the primary transponder housing. He stared at the wiring bank. Weeks ago, when he had taken that violent, clumsy bump against the heavy hull plating while trying to pull his illegal scoop maneuver, the transponder's primary coax cable hadn't severed. Instead, the force of the impact had popped the metal connector off its housing, creating a tiny, microscopic cavity in the junction box. The transponder had been powering on the whole time. But instead of broadcasting the strike message into open space, the signal energy had been trapped inside the cavity, scrambling itself into an unreadable, ultra-weak mess of local noise. It had never reached the fleet. It had never reached the corporate receivers. He hadn't been participating in the strike at all. For three weeks, while he had suffered agonies of fear, pride, and revolutionary fervor—convinced he was standing shoulder-to-shoulder with his brave sweeper brothers against the corporate machine—he had simply been a guy sitting in a dark, broken ship with a loose cable. A wild, manic wave of emotion crashed over him. He started laughing—a harsh, breathless, hysterical laugh that echoed hollowly in his small cockpit. It was the ultimate, cosmic joke. He hadn't defied the corporation. He hadn't risked the ice. He was just a pathetic, forty-eight-year-old idiot who didn't know how to inspect his own antenna connections. When the laughter finally died down, a cold, hollow feeling of utter smallness took its place. He cried. He cried like never before... not knowing if he was sleeping or not, just staring, yet after some time life came back to him... everything was so heavy, but still, every move felt not worth it, yet... "I have to." He went back to business. He fixed the cable and plugged the transponder back into the main bus. After a few hours, he received an immediate automated summons to report to the central corporate mining asteroid.

Marek was ordered to dress in his official corporate dress uniform—a rigid, uncomfortable dress-parade tunic he hadn't worn since the honors ceremony after the Samson-47 disaster. When he stepped off the shuttle at the high-tier corporate sector hub, he wasn't led to a security lockup or a crew briefing room. He was escorted down a series of pristine, carpeted corridors, far away from the grease and dust of the sweeper docks, stopping in front of a heavy, pressurized oak-veneer door. The guard opened the door, and Marek stepped inside. The chamber was massive, bathed in soft, warm light, overlooking the vast expanse of the asteroid ring through a floor-to-ceiling reinforced viewport. Standing near the glass, sipping a dark liquid from a crystal glass, was Leila. She looked as impossibly radiant, sharp, and untouchable as she had the day he pulled the manual lever on the Samson-47. Marek stood frozen in his stiff dress tunic, his heart hammering against his ribs. For two years, in the quiet dark of his sweeper cockpit, he had built a mountain of bitter justifications in his head. He had convinced himself that she was a monster. He had blamed her for Adam's death—telling himself she had taken Adam with her into sub-deck G7 specifically to prey on him, to steal his oxygen, to use him as a meat shield so she and her Navy boyfriend could live. Leila turned around. She didn't offer a warm smile. She didn't flash the blinding, magnetic charisma she used on the deck hands. She looked at Marek with cold, piercing disgust. "Shut up, Marek," she said quietly, before he could even open his mouth. "Don't speak. Just stand there and listen." Marek swallowed hard, pinned to the floor by her gaze. "I know exactly what you are," she said, her voice dropping into a razor-sharp whisper. "I know people like you. I've watched you. You sit in your dirty little corners, nursing your pathetic little grievances, convincing yourself that everyone higher than you on the corporate ladder is an evil villain, just so you can feel good about your own miserable, useless existence." She took a slow step toward him, her designer boots clicking sharply on the polished deck. "You think I murdered Adam, don't you? You've spent the last two years telling yourself that I took his oxygen, that I dragged him down into G7 just to survive. Alex spoke to the Captain after the rescue. Alex told me all about his suspicions regarding you. How low you are. How desperate you are. The death of Adam isn't on my hands, Marek. It's on yours." Marek's breath hitched, but Leila cut him off with a sharp flick of her wrist. "Adam was clearing the maintenance path himself," she spat. "He was a proud crewman—a real spaceman, unlike a bitter station rat like you. When a structural support beam snapped in the corridor, Alex tried to push him out of the way. If Alex hadn't jumped, that beam would have sliced Adam in half. By the time we

reached him, his suit seal was ruined, his ribs were crushed, and his oxygen tank was empty. He was already dead before we hit the G7 hatch. He admired me. He died trying to keep the sector clear. I didn't steal his oxygen, Marek—there was no oxygen to steal." She stopped inches from him, looking up into his pale, hollow face with pure contempt. "You despise us," she whispered. "You think you're better than everyone on this hull because you read technical manuals and draw on whiteboards. But Alex told me what the Captain figured out... You fried a quantum module because you were playing pretend genius in your bunk. And then you shook the whole ship with Alternator 5 just to hide your own embarrassing mistake." Marek felt as if the room had completely lost pressure. His knees trembled beneath his parade trousers. "I've been watching your sweep numbers from the beginning," she continued coldly. "Every cycle, I thought, This is it. This half-year, he fails his quota, and we quietly recycle him. And yet you always dodged by a slim chance. And then I thought just a 10% hike and it is over for you. And yet, here you stand, and you have no idea how much trouble you bring upon me." She turned her back on him, walking slowly back toward the viewport. "Alex told me about a lever," she said, her tone dripping with quiet cruelty. "You dragged that lever for my pod because you couldn't bear to see my face die. The Captain told him. Now... get out of my sight. Your audience is over."

Marek walked out of the chamber in a complete, silent daze. His mind was entirely numb, shattered under the weight of her words. As he reached the administrative exit, an official corporate liaison was waiting for him with an encrypted tablet. He looked at Marek in an odd way, with sheer respect. "Ah, Technician Marek," the liaison said, offering a sterile, professional smile. "Congratulations." Marek blinked, his voice a raspy whisper. "Congratulations?" "Your record during the recent labor dispute has been reviewed by senior management," the liaison explained, tapping the tablet. "While over ninety percent of the sweeping fleet engaged in illegal, mutinous strike actions, your vessel maintained active operational status throughout the entire crisis. Furthermore, your historical commendations from the Samson-47 incident demonstrate an unwavering, if somewhat eccentric, loyalty to corporate interests. The Lady personally insisted on granting a congratulatory audience, which is a great privilege." The liaison handed him the tablet. "Effective immediately, you are being promoted out of single-person sweeper operations. You are being reassigned to the Sector Fleet Management Division as a Regional Overseer." Marek stared at the glowing document. "You will no longer be piloting—loyal people like us are for better things, we are just different from the rest," the liaison continued, his voice smooth. "Your new responsibility will be overseeing the remaining sweepers in this sector—specifically, managing the implementation of the Efficiency-10 motion and reprisal on those suckers who dared to participate in the strike." The liaison leaned in slightly, lowering his voice into a conspiratorial whisper. "Unofficially? She barely ever even talks to the low-born. You have to be different, and loyal, unlike this scum..." He shook Marek's hand and went on a rant, but Marek went numb, barely registering the words. Marek looked down at his trembling, gloved hands, wrapped in the pristine, ridiculous fabric of his corporate dress tunic. His mind was like a hive now: Promotion, Adam, Efficiency-10... Leila. Finally, he whispered: "No, Leila... he was just a workhorse to you, and he died a workhorse for you..."